

Cocker Spaniels have a surprisingly long history, evolving from general "land spaniels" into the specific, merry companions we know today. Their name actually comes from their specialty in hunting **woodcock**, a notoriously difficult game bird.

Here is a timeline of the breed's evolution:

The Early Origins (1300s – 1700s)

- **1300s:** Spaniels are first mentioned in literature. Gaston III, Count of Foix, describes them in *Livre de Chasse* as dogs from Spain (*Espainols*) used for flushing game.
- **1500s – 1600s:** Spaniels begin to be categorized by where they worked: **Land Spaniels** and **Water Spaniels**.
- **1620:** The first spaniel arrives in New England (America) aboard the *Mayflower*.

The Specialized Hunter (1800s)

- **1801:** Sydenham Edwards' *Cynographia Britannica* formally divides Land Spaniels into two types: the **Springing Spaniel** (larger) and the **Cocking Spaniel** (smaller).
- **1850s – 1860s:** "Cocker" is still a size description rather than a breed. If a spaniel pup in a litter weighed under **25 lbs**, it was called a Cocker; if it was over 25 lbs, it was a Field or Springer Spaniel.
- **1878:** The American Kennel Club (AKC) registers its first Cocker Spaniel, a liver-and-white dog named **Captain**.
- **1879:** **Ch. Obo** is born in England. He is considered the "foundation sire" of the modern English Cocker Spaniel.
- **1881:** **Ch. Obo II** (Obo's son) is born. He is moved to America and becomes the foundation sire of the American Cocker Spaniel.

Breed Formalization (1890s – 1940s)

- **1892:** The Kennel Club (UK) officially recognizes the Cocker Spaniel as a distinct breed.
- **1901:** The 25-pound weight limit is finally abolished, allowing the breed to be defined by "type" and appearance rather than just the scales.
- **1935:** The AKC recognizes the English and American types as separate "varieties."
- **1936 – 1952:** The Cocker Spaniel becomes the **#1 most popular dog breed** in the United States.
- **1946:** The AKC officially splits them into two entirely separate breeds: the **English Cocker Spaniel** and the **Cocker Spaniel** (the American version).

Pop Culture & Modern Era (1950s – Present)

- **1952:** Richard Nixon's "Checkers" speech features his family's American Cocker Spaniel, making the breed a household name in political history.
- **1955:** Disney releases *Lady and the Tramp*, featuring Lady, a doe-eyed American Cocker

Spaniel, cementing the breed's image as a glamorous companion.

- **1970:** The UK Kennel Club finally recognizes the American Cocker Spaniel as a separate breed from the English Cocker.
- **Present:** Today, the **English Cocker** remains a popular working and show dog in Europe, while the **American Cocker** is primarily celebrated as a show dog and family pet with a more profuse coat.

Fun Fact: Because of their cheerful nature and constantly wagging tails, the breed is famously nicknamed the "**Merry Cocker.**"

Would you like me to find some images of the physical differences between the English and American varieties?